

NEW GROUNDRULES

Several well-entrenched parliamentarians are likely to be turfed out of their traditional strongholds if the delimitation panel's recommendations are effected before the next polls

■ By Satarupa Bhattachariya

When the country heads for the next Lok Sabha elections, which are less than a year and half away, conventional wisdom in Rajasthan's Dausa constituency offers one certainty. Sachin Pilot, the incumbent MP will win for a second time the seat that his father and mother had, between them, won eight times since 1984. But the 28-year-old Congress MP, who had won in 2004 with a margin of over 1.2 lakh votes is not so sure of the margin now. And the reason is a single word—delimitation.

With the Government accepting Justice Kuldip Singh Delimitation Commission report and a notification

now imminent, Dausa seat will be reserved for Scheduled Tribes (ST). Pilot is a Gujar whose community is outnumbered by Meenas. Earlier this year, Gujjars and Meenas had fought a bloody war over Constitutional recognition. Pilot had demanded that Gujjars be moved to the ST category, which already has Meenas. The Gujar-Meena conflict over identities is more than a decade old but a significant reason for Pilot's desperation is the outcome of the delimitation process. A majority of Dausa electors have voted for the Pilot family in six consecutive parliamentary polls. With the delimitation panel deciding to reserve the seat for ST, Pilot might not remain the Congress's best bet here in future elections, unless the

Gujjars, too, are declared ST soon.

Although the new panel chaired by Singh has completed the process in 25 states and Union territories, some politicians are upset with the results. Major political parties, however, seem to have agreed to apply the new constituencies' configuration in the next general elections. The Supreme Court would, in coming days, take up pending litigations against the commission and the UPA Government filed by MPs, MLAs and social organisations.

In this season of electoral apprehensions, Pilot is not alone. Political biggies such as Lok Sabha speaker Somnath Chatterjee, who has been elected from West Bengal's Bolpur constituency 10 times, could be af-



SOMNATH CHATTERJEE
BOLPUR

Won 10 times. Now the Speaker's constituency may be reserved.



LALU PRASAD YADAV
CHAPRA

A part of his constituency is likely to be transferred to an adjoining seat.



RAMVILAS PASWAN
HAJIPUR

Assiduously built up the SC constituency which is now likely to be deserved.



SHIVRAJ PATIL
LATUR

In line for reservation, the constituency could be a harder nut to crack.

SIPRA DAS

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

PANKAJ NANGIA

PANKAJ NANGIA